



SEE THE FUTURE STARTUP COMPETITION 2026 · COLUMBIA CLIMATE SCHOOL

BetterBarter

A campus reuse board that **counts what it keeps out of the skip** — one confirmed handoff at a time, on a model we published so you can argue with it.

THE PROBLEM

A working desk is thrown out because the term ended.

Move-out compresses a year of disposal into one week. Furniture, textiles and small electronics leave residence halls in skips while, ten days later, the next intake buys the same objects new. The material is fine. The **timing and the distance** are what fail.

Columbia already runs **Give + Go Green** and **Clean + Go Green** at check-out, and they work — but collection catches what is *left at the end*. Nothing moves an object from one student to another *before* the pile forms, which is the cheaper step and the higher one on the EPA hierarchy.

And reuse is measured at the truck

A donation drive reports a weight, after the fact, in aggregate — so a sustainability office cannot defend the number, and what cannot be reported does not get funded.



One campus, one board, one confirmed handoff at a time.

Walled to one campus

A university email maps to a campus in the database. Row-level security means a query cannot cross the wall, not that the interface hides it. Verified tested, not asserted.

Zero logistics

Two students crossing a campus they were crossing anyway. No van, no packaging, no collection round — so the transport term of the saving is genuinely nil.

Counted at the object

Both sides confirm the handoff in person. One event, one category, one timestamp — a circularity metric a sustainability office can defend line by line.

It is not an alternative to Give + Go Green. The board takes the easy majority out of the pile before it forms, so staffed collection can deal with what actually needs handling.

Not a mockup — a deployed product on a live backend.

The board

Browsed by category, colour-coded free / sale / swap, with a "gone by" date because a thing in a room somebody must empty by Friday is not a thing for sale.

The handoff code

Six digits split across two phones — the buyer holds three, the seller three, and the database gives neither the other half.

The safety net

Contact details cannot be sent in chat. Reporting hides an account instantly and files it. Rate limits live in the database, not the client.

SSO

University sign-in only

RLS

Campus wall in Postgres

PWA

Installable, and a desktop app

Open

Source, and the model with it

The measurement cannot be raised by one person alone.

Six digits, split down the middle

The buyer's app shows the first three, the seller's the last three, and neither can read the other's — the column is not readable by any client. Those six digits do not exist in one place until two people are standing together.

And the honest limit: two people set on faking a handoff can read the digits to each other. It cannot happen by accident, it cannot happen alone, and faking it takes a deliberate conversation inside a thread that is on the record.

Every other campus reuse figure we can find is self-reported or weighed at a truck. Ours is reported in two tiers, and only the first is evidence:

Verified in person	two halves, joined
Taken on trust	both tapped, nothing proved

The founders' dashboard shows them side by side, and the second number is never quoted as the first.

Three levels, kept apart, so nobody has to take our word for the third.

MEASURED

1 object

A confirmed handoff. Counted, not estimated. This is the only number that is observed.

ESTIMATED

3.45 kg

Mass kept in use, from a published factor table weighted to a category mix of small things, not one carried by bikes and laptops.

ESTIMATED + ADJUSTED

7.2 kg

CO₂e avoided, at a **displacement rate of 0.5** — we assume only half of reuse events prevent a purchase.

The assumption most likely to be challenged, given away before anyone asks: a rented object earns no carbon credit at all in this model, because it comes back. It is recorded as a reuse event and nothing more.

Sources: EPA *Advancing Sustainable Materials Management* (durable goods, textiles); EPA GHG Emission Factors Hub; EPA Waste Management Hierarchy; NCES IPEDS enrolment; WRAP, *Environmental and Economic Benefits of Re-use*. Factor table, mix and arithmetic are in one file in the open repository.

The arithmetic, shown so it can be checked.

	OBJECTS A YEAR	MASS	CO ₂ E AVOIDED	HOW IT IS DERIVED
TAM	≈46M	≈159,000 t	≈333,000 t	15.4M US undergraduates (NCES) × 3 reusable objects each
SAM	≈14M	≈48,000 t	≈101,000 t	the ~30% on residential campuses dense enough for a board to work
SOM · year 3	≈300,000	≈1,000 t	≈2,160 t	25 campuses at a 15% participation rate

Every figure above is the published per-object model multiplied by a student count we did not invent.
Change the displacement rate and the third column moves — which is the point of printing the rate.

The university pays. The students never do.

Campus licence · \$15k a year

Priced against a cost the university already carries: move-out hauling, plus the circularity reporting it has to produce anyway. What the licence buys is object-level, auditable reuse data it currently cannot get at any price.

No cut of a handoff. Ever.

No listing fee, no commission, no escrow. Money between two students moves the way it already does, and we never touch it — which is also why the data stays clean and why nobody has an incentive to inflate it.

\$58M

TAM
3,896 US degree-granting institutions (NCES)

\$18M

SAM
~1,200 residential four-year campuses

\$375k

SOM · year 3
25 licensed campuses, ~2% of the serviceable set

WHERE WE ACTUALLY ARE

Working product. Pre-pilot. We would rather say so.



Shipped and running

University SSO · campus-isolated Postgres with row-level security · realtime chat with contact details blocked · photo storage · the day-7 freshness check on an hourly job · community-rules gate · pre-post safety check · split-code handoff confirmation · ratings · reports and a moderation queue · database-level rate limits · installable PWA.

Not yet

No paying customers. No institutional partnership. No pilot users — two verified Columbia accounts, and both of them are us.

The pilot window is now: Columbia's first-years moved in on 29–30 August and orientation runs to 7 September. It is the one week of the year when the demand side of a campus reuse board is standing in front of you with an empty room.

THE TEAM, AND WHAT WE WANT FROM YOU

A pilot campus, and people willing to argue with the model.

Agung Nugroho

Columbia SPS. Marketing — CRM, lifecycle and growth. Builds and runs the product, the impact model and the data.

Tessa Wong

Columbia. Product and partnerships — the community rules, the listing experience, and the route into housing and sustainability offices.

What we need

One residential campus willing to pilot at move-out 2027, an introduction to a housing or sustainability office, and a hard read of the displacement assumption.